

FINANCE 04



Student Loans
Working while studying
Wealth inequality

30002651 20"20"06 7038634357

Growing up,

we were taught to believe that going to university was the only path towards a successful career. But, in the midst of the cost-of-living crisis, students are tirelessly working alongside their studies.

All quotes in this zine come directly from University of Reading students studying in the School of Arts and Communication Design, and were shared anonymously through a survey for the Different by Design project. The survey invited students to speak openly about their experiences of university life.

"I find working alongside my studies difficult. But I could not afford to do my MA if I did not work"

"I feel like I am working 7 days a week, I'm exhausted a lot of the time and don't really have any other choice"

"I am finding the balance hard but I hope I will get there with it one day and it will all be worth it"

"Some days I think about how I will never be able to pay off my loan and wonder if going to university was the right decision"

[[Survey responses, 2025]]

65%

Surveyed students, nationwide, work part-time while studying.

[[Censuswide & Aviva, 2025]]

This gives them less time to dedicate to their assignments and more mental clutter to sort through while trying to learn.

At the same time, 'Plan 2' student loan changes have made graduates' debt increase faster than monthly repayments.

[[Rethink Repayment, 2026]]

This has created an ecosystem where graduates from underprivileged backgrounds cannot pay off their loans and have an increasingly harder time saving money.

The cost of 'creativity' in 2026

Adobe Creative Cloud Pro 2026.....£797.88
Newest macbook.....£2000
Daily coffee.....£3.50
AI?!?.....ERROR
Student loan.....£40,000
Late nights & poor sleep.....%UNDEFINED%
I should remake my portfolio.....<h1>no<h1/>
There's new software i need?!.....*ffini*y
Will I get a job after graduating?...?????????
Printing costs.....ERROR
Excessive paper.....UNSUSTAINBLE
A social life?...null-entry
My overdraft is about to max out.....>CORTISOL
Will I be able to pay rent?.....INT-ERROR
I love typography?...<><><><><>
Neglected health.....NHS-VISIT
Joint aches & back pain.....CHIROPRACTOR
Sedentry lifestyle.....DEPRESSION
Imposter syndrome.....%UNDEFINED%
NewFinalFinalV4.psd.....1.56gb
ClientPngLogo.docx.....{-_-}
Premium Typeface.....£700
Alignment issues.....<*>
Group working dynamics.....!!!!!!!!!!!!!!
Why is it still raining.....UK-WEATHER
Spending entire day indoors.....SEDENTARY
Maybe I should go into UI/UX.....CORPORATE
When will I see my family next?.....CHRISTMAS?
Printing issues.....AGAIN
Reliance on external validation.....*(&^>#*""]
'Make it pop'.....REALLY????
Am I doing enough networking?.....HOPEFULLY
What if it doesn't work out.....EXHAUSTED
Typeface choices.....e+146
Commute into office.....****-****
Following my passion.....<INVALUABLE>
Seeing your work in person.....!PRICELESS!

*** TOTAL: £45,000+ in student debt, unclear
future career options & self doubt with a side of
fufillment ***

NO REFUNDS
NO EXCHANGES
NO RETURNS



Know that you aren't alone. Nor are you doing anything wrong. You were sold a future that was robbed from under your feet. All we can do now is to be there for one another and fight for social justice. It won't come easy and it will take a long time for the current conditions to wane but there is hope. Choosing to have a creative career is incredibly fulfilling and we get to use our skills for good. It takes some grit and determination but I would not trade it for anything. Ultimately, creativity is a divine gift, craft and a tool which no school or university can really teach. They can teach structure,

discipline, group working skills, technical skills and a host of other fundamentals but true creativity is pure and sacred. Protect it with your might, and use it for good. I truly believe that the universe will self-organise itself into a system that rewards those in true alignment. Be kind to others and try your best to not succumb to the evil forces that seemingly run this world. Keep creating, learning and try to do your best to be a force for good.

All love.
Aurelien Flatman
Part 2, BA Graphic Communication student



'I am, we are ... different by design' is an annual student-led zine published by the Department of Typography & Graphic Communication at the University of Reading. This year, the zine was curated, collated and designed by Eleanor Denton, Aurelien Flatman, Grace Johnson, and Jess Scrivener.

This year's edition focuses on four themes: mental health, menstrual health, community & inclusion, and student finances. These were the most commonly raised issues that students in the School of Arts and Communication Design highlighted to us in a survey.

In the University's 100th year, we have brought together and presented under-represented student voices from across the School.

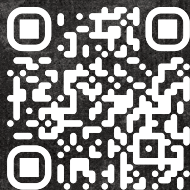
Design by Aurelien Flatman



Creative lives in
progress



Creative
conscience



Build list

Sources

Censuswide & Aviva (2025) [aviva.com/newsroom/news-releases/2025/10/new-research-reveals-how-the-student-side-hustle-has-evolved-across-the-decades](https://www.aviva.com/newsroom/news-releases/2025/10/new-research-reveals-how-the-student-side-hustle-has-evolved-across-the-decades)

(Accessed 15-01-26)

Rethink Repayment (2026)

rethinkrepayment.com

(Accessed 15-01-26)